

ACTIVITY 1 — LEARNER WORKSHEET**Define — Customer Requirements and the Problem Statement**

TYPE	DURATION	MAPS TO	TOPIC
Hands-on Activity	30 minutes	DEFINE	Define — Understand the Problem

Name	
Date	

What you are doing

BrewBean Cafe is a busy coffee shop in the CBD serving mainly office workers on their way to work. Over the past two months online complaints about slow service have been rising, and several regulars have said they now buy their coffee elsewhere. Management has formed a small improvement team and you have joined it as the White Belt member, supporting the team rather than leading the project.

What you will produce: A VOC-to-CTQ table with five measurable requirements, a written problem statement containing no solution, a SMART goal, and an in/out scope table.

The scenario

Nobody in the cafe agrees on what the problem actually is. The owner thinks the team needs a second coffee machine. The morning barista says the queue is fine and customers are simply impatient. One of the baristas is convinced the real issue is that orders keep coming out wrong. No one has asked the customers, and no one has written the problem down.

Before the team spends a dollar, your job is to find out what customers actually want, turn that into something measurable, and state the problem clearly enough that everyone in the room agrees on it.

Your steps

1. **Read the scenario and the raw feedback** — Open data/voc-raw-customer-feedback.csv (or the Excel workbook) and read all 30 pieces of customer feedback — online reviews, comment cards and counter remarks. Underline every complaint you can find. Read before you write: the most common reason improvement projects fail is that the team decided what the problem was before looking at the evidence.
2. **Capture five VOC statements in the customer's own words** — Using templates/voc-to-ctq-template.csv, write down five Voice of the Customer statements quoted from the Verbatim Comment column. Keep the customer's own words — 'I'm late for work because the queue is too slow', not 'customers desire improved service efficiency'. The translation happens in the next step, not here.

3. **Turn each VOC into a measurable CTQ** — For each VOC statement, write what the customer actually needs, then a Critical to Quality requirement that carries BOTH a number AND a unit — 'served within 5 minutes', not 'served faster'. If you cannot put a number on it, you cannot tell later whether you fixed it.
4. **Write the problem statement** — In templates/problem-statement-and-scope-template.csv, fill the four components: what is wrong, where and when it happens, since when, and how big it is — then the impact on the business. Write NO solution. 'Because we need to open a second till' is a solution and invalidates the statement.
5. **Test the goal against SMART** — Rewrite your goal so it is Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant and Time-bound. A complete goal names a metric, a baseline, a target and a date. Note the difference from the problem statement: the problem is what is wrong TODAY; the goal is what will be true at the END.
6. **Agree the scope** — Fill the in-scope / out-of-scope rows so the team knows where the project stops. Test each item with: could a White Belt team finish that in six weeks? Anything needing capital spend or a supplier renegotiation goes out of scope.
7. **Prepare the debrief line** — Agree one sentence: "Our problem statement passes because it says ____, and it contains no solution." Nominate a spokesperson to read it out.

Your working space

Complete every field. You may keep this worksheet and refer to it during the open-book assessment.

Step 1 — Read the scenario and the raw feedback

Step 2 — Capture five VOC statements in the customer's own words

Step 3 — Turn each VOC into a measurable CTQ

Step 4 — Write the problem statement

Step 5 — Test the goal against SMART

Step 6 — Agree the scope

Step 7 — Prepare the debrief line

Answers to the discussion prompts

1. Reading the raw feedback, what are customers actually asking for — and how does that differ from what the owner assumed the problem was?

2. Which of your CTQ requirements would be the hardest to measure in a real cafe, and how would you measure it anyway?

3. What makes a problem statement useful to an improvement team, and what makes one useless?

4. Why does a White Belt project need an explicit out-of-scope list?

Reflect & discuss

Did your problem statement contain a hidden solution on the first attempt? Most do.

Which piece of customer feedback surprised you most compared with what you expected to find?

If the owner insists on buying the second coffee machine anyway, what would you say using only your VOC and CTQ table?

Check your work

Every group can show five VOC statements in the customer's own words, five CTQs each carrying a number and a unit, and a problem statement containing no solution.